

The APTO AI Starter Kit

20 copy-paste AI prompts for small business owners who want to save time, write better and automate the boring stuff — starting today.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- ◆ 20 ready-to-use AI prompts across 5 categories
- ◆ How to use ChatGPT and Claude for free
- ◆ The 5 free tools that replace expensive software
- ◆ A weekly workflow you can set up in one afternoon
- ◆ Bonus: 10 Pinterest pin title formulas

Free resource from **APTO** · apto.beehiiv.com

Why AI tools matter for your business

Most small business owners spend 15–20 hours per week on tasks that AI can do in minutes: writing emails, drafting proposals, creating social media posts, responding to customer queries and planning content.

The problem isn't that the tools are hard to use. The problem is knowing *which* tool to use, *how* to ask it the right questions, and *where* to start without getting overwhelmed.

"The best AI tool is the one you actually use. Start with one prompt. Build from there."

How to use this guide

This kit is organised into five sections. Each prompt has a clear label showing what category it's for, the exact text to copy into ChatGPT or Claude, and a short note on how to adapt it.

- Replace every **[bracketed section]** with your specific details before using
- Works with **ChatGPT free** (GPT-4o), **Claude free**, or any AI assistant
- The more specific you are, the better the output
- Save your favourite prompts somewhere — you'll reuse them every week

■ **TIP:** Start with just one prompt from Section 1. Use it today. The goal is progress, not perfection.

The prompts you'll use every single week

Email and writing tasks eat more time than almost anything else. These prompts cover the situations that come up repeatedly in every small business.

PROMPT 01 FOLLOW-UP EMAIL

"Write a professional follow-up email to [client name] about [proposal/quote/meeting]. Keep it under 80 words. Friendly but direct. End with one clear next step."

Change "professional" to "warm" or "casual" depending on your relationship with the client.

PROMPT 02 PROPOSAL DRAFT

"Write a business proposal for [client name] who needs [specific service]. Include: brief overview, our approach, timeline (leave as [INSERT TIMELINE]), and a pricing placeholder. Tone: confident and clear, not salesy. 400-500 words."

Paste this into a document and fill in the pricing section manually.

PROMPT 03 CUSTOMER COMPLAINT RESPONSE

"Write a professional response to a customer who complained about [describe the issue]. Acknowledge the problem, apologise sincerely, explain what happened briefly, and state the next step to resolve it. Under 120 words."

Always add a personal sign-off. AI copy without personalisation can feel cold.

PROMPT 04 COLD OUTREACH EMAIL

"Write a cold outreach email for [your business/service] targeting [type of business]. Lead with a specific insight about their business. Offer one clear value. Short CTA. Maximum 100 words. Avoid generic openers like "I hope this finds you well.""

Test two versions with different first lines and see which gets more replies.

PROMPT 05 RE-ENGAGEMENT EMAIL

"Write an email to re-engage a [client/lead] who went quiet after [last contact point]. Don't be pushy. Add a small piece of value (tip, insight, or useful resource). Leave the door open. Under 80 words."

This prompt works best when you add something genuinely useful in the "value" section.

Create a week of content in under an hour

Social media content is one of the easiest tasks to hand off to AI — as long as you give it enough context. These prompts include your audience, tone and format so the output is actually usable.

PROMPT 06 INSTAGRAM / FACEBOOK POST

"Write 3 social media posts about [topic] for [describe your audience]. Format: one "story" post (personal, 1st person), one "tip" post (listicle), one "question" post (conversation starter). Each under 150 words. Tone: [friendly/professional/casual]."

Pick the format that matches your brand voice, not all three.

PROMPT 07 LINKEDIN POST

"Write a LinkedIn post about [topic or recent achievement]. Hook in the first line (no "I'm excited to share" openers). Add a short insight or lesson. End with one question to spark conversation. 150–200 words."

LinkedIn rewards specificity. Add real numbers or a real example wherever you can.

PROMPT 08 PINTEREST PIN TITLES

"Generate 10 Pinterest pin title ideas for content about [topic]. Target audience: [describe them]. Mix formats: how-to, listicle, question, bold statement, comparison. Each title under 70 characters. Make them searchable."

Pinterest is a search engine. Use the exact words your audience would type.

PROMPT 09 PRODUCT/SERVICE DESCRIPTION

"Write a product description for [product/service name]. Target customer: [describe them]. Three main benefits: [list them]. Tone: [describe your brand voice]. Length: 80–120 words. End with a clear call to action."

Avoid "revolutionary" and "game-changing" — they've lost all meaning.

PROMPT 10 CONTENT CALENDAR IDEAS

"Generate 20 content ideas for [your business type] targeting [your audience]. Cover these themes: [list 3-4 themes]. Mix formats: educational tips, behind-the-scenes, product features, customer stories, opinion posts. Label each with a suggested format."

Use this once a month to fill your content calendar in one sitting.

The admin and planning prompts that save the most time

Operations work — policies, job posts, meeting prep, planning — is where AI genuinely earns its keep. These tasks take hours without AI and minutes with it.

PROMPT 11 **JOB DESCRIPTION**

"Write a job description for a [job title] role at a [type of business]. Include: role summary, 5 key responsibilities, 4 required skills, 2 nice-to-haves, and a short paragraph about the company culture. Tone: professional but human. Avoid corporate jargon."

Review the responsibilities section carefully — AI sometimes adds generic fluff.

PROMPT 12 **MEETING AGENDA**

"Create a structured agenda for a [type of meeting] with [number] people. Meeting duration: [X] minutes. Key topics to cover: [list them]. Include: time allocation per section, who leads each item, and 5 minutes at the end for next steps."

Send the agenda 24 hours in advance. Meetings without agendas waste everyone's time.

PROMPT 13 **PROCESS / SOP DOCUMENT**

"Write a standard operating procedure for [describe the process]. Format: numbered steps, clear language, no jargon. Include: purpose, who it applies to, step-by-step instructions, and what to do if something goes wrong."

SOPs are one of the highest-value things you can create for your business.

PROMPT 14 **FAQ PAGE**

"Write an FAQ section for [your product/service/website]. Generate 10 questions your customers typically ask, with concise honest answers. Include questions about: pricing, process, timeline, guarantees, and what makes you different."

Add the real questions your customers actually ask — pull from past emails.

PROMPT 15 **WEEKLY PLANNING PROMPT**

"It's Monday morning. Here are my priorities for this week: [list them]. Here are my current blockers: [list them]. Help me create a realistic daily plan for Monday to Friday, grouping similar tasks and protecting focused work time."

Use this every Monday. It takes 5 minutes and saves hours of decision fatigue.

Convert more, spend less time convincing

Marketing copy is one of the hardest things to write about your own business — you're too close to it. AI gives you a first draft from a customer's perspective. Edit it, but start here.

PROMPT 16 LANDING PAGE COPY

"Write landing page copy for [product/service]. Target customer: [describe them in one sentence]. Their main problem: [describe it]. Our solution: [describe it]. Include: headline, subheadline, 3 benefit bullets, social proof placeholder, and a call to action button."

The headline is everything. Ask AI to give you 5 variations and pick the best one.

PROMPT 17 AD COPY (FACEBOOK/GOOGLE)

"Write a [Facebook / Google] ad for [product/service]. Target audience: [describe them]. Primary pain point: [describe it]. Provide: primary headline (under 40 chars), body copy (under 125 words), and 3 call-to-action options."

Test one variable at a time. Start with different headlines on the same audience.

PROMPT 18 SALES PAGE — SHORT FORM

"Write a short-form sales page for [digital product/service] priced at [price]. Include: attention-grabbing headline, problem statement, solution overview, 5 benefit bullets (outcome-focused, not feature-focused), who it's for, who it's NOT for, and a clear CTA."

The "who it's NOT for" section builds trust. Don't skip it.

PROMPT 19 TESTIMONIAL REQUEST EMAIL

"Write a short email to [client name] asking for a testimonial. They recently [describe positive outcome]. Make it easy: give them 3 optional questions to answer. Under 100 words. Warm and genuinely grateful in tone."

Send this within a week of a good result — that's when clients are most motivated to respond.

PROMPT 20 PRICING PAGE COPY

"Write copy for a simple 3-tier pricing page for [your product/service]. Tiers: [name 1] at [price 1], [name 2] at [price 2], [name 3] at [price 3]. For each tier: include what's included, who it's best for, and one line that makes the middle tier feel like the obvious choice."

The middle tier should always be the one you most want people to choose.

The free stack and the system that ties it together

The 5 free tools we actually use

Tool	What it does	Free plan
ChatGPT	Writing, research, ideas, summaries	GPT-4o included
Canva	Designs, Pinterest pins, PDFs, social posts	Unlimited designs
Make.com	Automate tasks between apps (no code)	1,000 ops/month
Beehiiv	Newsletter platform with referral tools	Up to 2,500 subs
HubSpot CRM	Contact management, pipeline, email tracking	Free forever

The Monday morning workflow (30 minutes)

1. Open ChatGPT (5 min)	Paste the Weekly Planning Prompt (Prompt 15). Copy your priorities from last week's notes. Get your daily plan.
2. Batch content (15 min)	Use Prompt 6, 7 or 8 depending on your platform. Generate 5 posts for the week. Drop into Canva for design.
3. Clear the inbox (10 min)	Use Prompts 1–5 for any emails that need drafting. Review and personalise before sending. Never send AI copy unedited.

■ **TIP:** The workflow above takes 30 minutes on Monday and saves 5+ hours across the week. Set a recurring Monday morning calendar block.

NEXT STEPS

You've got the kit. Here's what to do next.

Today	Pick one prompt. Use it for something real — an email, a social post, a proposal. See how it feels.
This week	Try the Monday workflow. Batch your content. Use the operations prompts for one admin task you've been putting off.
This month	Build your own prompt library. Keep a notes doc of the prompts that work best for your business.
Ongoing	Subscribe to the APTO newsletter for one new tool review and one new workflow every Tuesday.

Get the weekly APTO newsletter

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